resources. "This was a rare instance of the party being unable to come to a consensus over a candidate. It had to be done urgently: urban local body polls are due soon," says a source.

Panchal, who changed his surname to Vishwakarma to represent his community, is a minister of state in the Bhupendra Patel government. He was in the fray primarily owing to his caste—among the 160-plus OBC groups in Gujarat. His organisational past too played a role: over the years, the booth worker had gradually risen up the ranks, becoming Ahmedabad city unit president and industry cell convenor, while developing business interests in textiles and real estate.

Vishwakarma is also said to enjoy the confidence of Prime Minister



Takeaways

- **After two-year search, BJP settles on OBC face as its Gujarat party chief**
- **After C.R. Paatil (above), Vishwakarma has big shoes to fill, with local polls ahead**

Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah, who are known to micromanage the affairs of Gujarat. He also enjoys a congenial equation with CM Patel, an old city-mate. He does not have RSS roots, as was anticipated of the new president—perhaps why the call took so long. But the day after his appointment, he joined an RSS function in his area of Amraiwadi in Ahmedabad, photos of which were released by the RSS.

However, it's his OBC profile that seems to have tipped the scales. In 2020, he had led meetings with Ahmedabad's OBC Morcha office-bearers to address local issues, such as reservations in local bodies. He also joined BJP delegations to the state OBC commission, pushing for proportional quotas in panchayats based on population data, aligning with Supreme Court directives, which resulted in the state government granting 27 per cent reservation for OBCs in local body polls.

NEXT STEP: RESHUFFLE

With a Patidar as CM and an OBC as state president, the BJP's caste representation settles well, but it's a rare time when both key incumbents are from Ahmedabad. To balance this disparity, a massive cabinet reshuffle is expected very soon. Speculation has been rife for months now that senior Congress turncoats, like its former chief and LoP Arjun Modhwadia, who joined the party ahead of 2022 polls, have to be rewarded.

That reshuffle will also relieve Vishwakarma of his portfolios, leaving him free to focus on the party. But he has big shoes to fill. During Paatil's tenure, the party won 156 out of 182 assembly seats in 2022. The tally has now swelled to 161, with five MLAs from the Congress and AAP hopping onto the gravy train.

The party arguably has a sterner test ahead than ever before. Within four months in early 2026, elections for 16 municipal corporations and 68 municipalities are due. These urban/peri-urban areas are a loyal BJP electorate, but anti-incumbency is a real concern—and global headwinds, US tariffs and crumbling infrastructure like bridge collapses and potholed roads do not help. Local polls are typically contested on governance and delivery, not emotive issues.

Also, factionalism has taken root, with the dozens of new inductees from the Congress replacing or competing with BJP old guard for tickets or cabinet berths. "Regional leaders feel demotivated, the cadre feel alienated," says an insider. No wonder Vishwakarma spent maximum time in his acceptance speech glorifying the grassroots worker, and identifying himself as one. ■

▶ HARYANA

A Two-Lan

The Congress opens up its Harya



By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

HARYANA'S POLITICAL MAP HAS TILTED a bit. Wrenching itself free of its singular reliance on ex-CM Bhupinder Singh Hooda's Jat overlordship, the Congress on September 29 named former minister Rao Narendra Singh as state president. Hooda will still head the legislative wing, CLP. The dual leadership is aimed at enabling a